

RIMA DAS, 45
Filmmaker
Kalardiya village, Assam

Stories of Her Land

Directing was not her original ambition, acting was. After years of rejection and being told her height, appearance and 'type' didn't work in front of a camera, it broke something inside Rima. "I started feeling small," she says. Her adopted home, Mumbai, nevertheless, opened another door. After increasing exposure to world cinema, she bought a Canon 5D DSLR and made her first feature, *Antardrishti* (*Man with the Binoculars*), about an old man looking back on life. She knew she had found her calling.

Her next film, *Village Rockstars*, about a girl whose dreams of buying a guitar get derailed by a devastating flood, was shot over nearly three years in her village with children from modest backgrounds, and restored something the years of rejection as an actor had taken away. "The process healed me," she says. The film premiered at Toronto, won National Awards for Best Feature Film and Best Editing and became India's official entry for the 2019 Academy Awards, the first Assamese film to achieve that distinction.

WHAT MAKES HER A SHERO

Rima's small-scale films have won over film fests everywhere, from Toronto to Berlin to India. The feather in her cap came last year, with *Not A Hero*, about a city boy adjusting to village life

Rima has gone from strength to strength ever since, her subsequent films premiering at the Toronto and Berlin international film festivals, and she was also invited to join the Academy of Motion Picture Arts and Sciences in 2024. Her latest production, *Not A Hero*, got a Crystal Bear Special Mention at the Berlin International Film Festival recently, marking another international milestone for a filmmaker whose cinema began far from studios, elaborate crews and big budgets. ■

— Priyanka Saharia

HER TAKE

"Even with a small camera, you can make a film, and that story can travel the world"